Just over a month earlier, in April 2018, the then BJP president Amit Shah had also visited Swamiji, along with the party's chief minister candidate, B.S. Yediyurappa, to start the poll campaign. In full view of the TV cameras, Shah reverentially prostrated on the ground and touched the octogenarian seer's feet with his forehead. Later, he announced that the aashirwaad (blessing) he had received from Swamiji would 'increase' the BJP's 'strength', giving it greater 'energy' and 'confidence' in the elections.[8] A week later, the then Congress president Rahul Gandhi followed suit. Visiting the Math, also in full view of the cameras, Gandhi presented Swamiji with a large bouquet of red-and-white roses before seeming to engage him in an animated conversation.[9] The televised visits of the two politicians underscored the seriousness with which both sides viewed the Lingayat vote, as also the role of caste and religion in the election campaign.

'Without Caste and Without Religion, There Is No Politics in India'

How do religious leaders at the Math view the politics of Lingayat reservations? What is their own positioning and how do they evaluate their influence? Curious about these questions, we paid a visit to the monastery. We were granted an audience with the institution's operative head, Sri Sri Siddalinga Mahaswamy, junior swamy and president of the Siddaganga Math. He was saffron-clad and turbaned, with white ash on his forehead, and sat in his office under a colourful portrait of a bejewelled Basavanna on a throne. He chose not to get drawn into political matters. Yet, his cryptic answer to my question on how he viewed the elections was revealing. 'Elections are for voting by each and everyone, but wherever you go, religion and caste are ridden with politics,' the fifty-five-year-old monk said. 'Without caste and without religion, there is no politics in India. That is bad, but we will hope that one day all will come out without religion and caste. But today we are seeing everyone running behind caste and religion.'

He denied that his Math had supported the reservation move for Lingayats and emphasised 'unity' as its core goal. 'The country,